

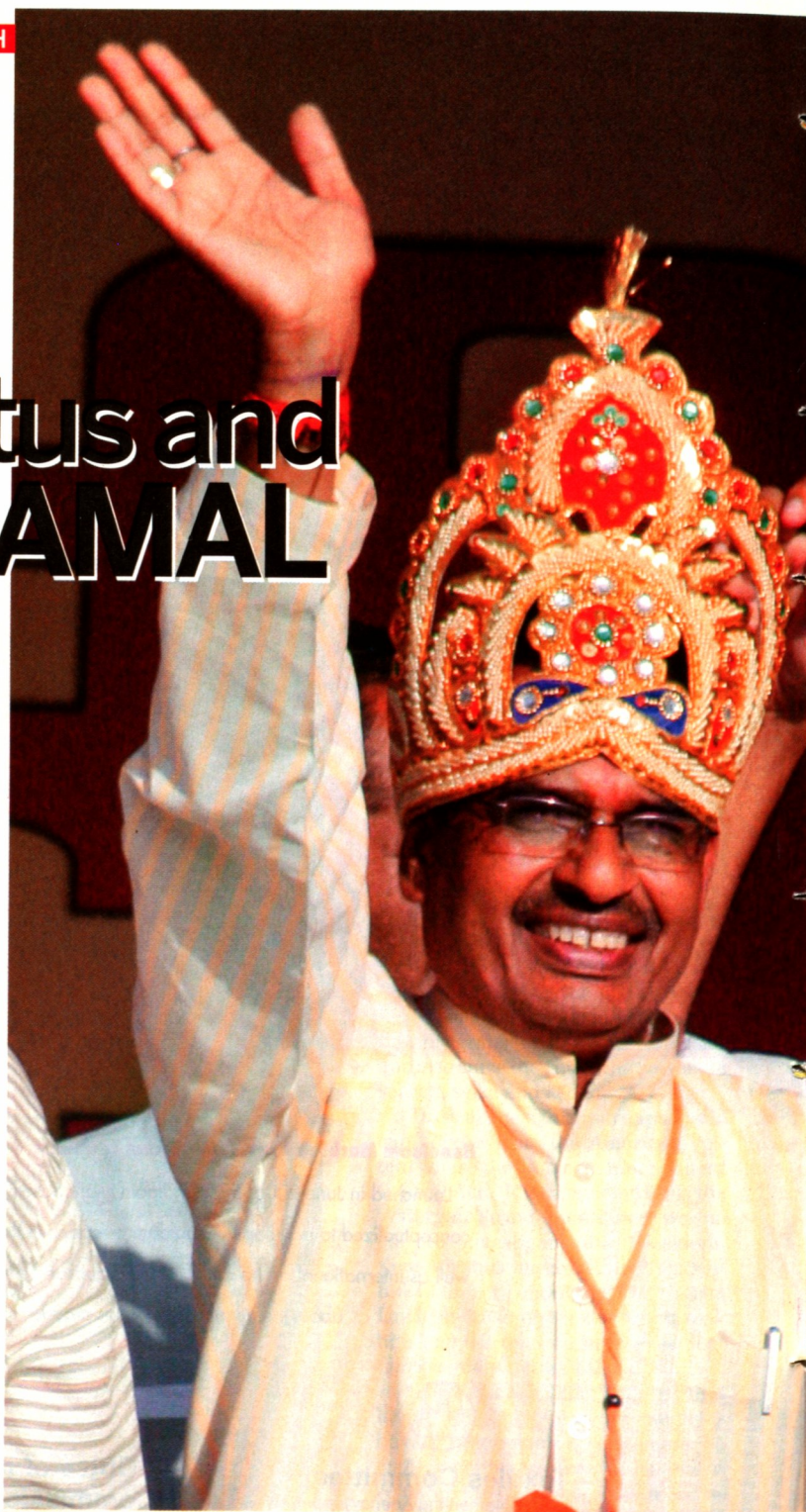
The Lotus and THE KAMAL

Despite his indifferent performance, incumbent Chouhan is the frontrunner

By Ambreesh Mishra

For close to three years, he lived a charmed life. The stink of the dumper scam dissipated quickly, a string of by-poll defeats was forgotten and an indifferent administrative performance as chief minister was brushed under the carpet. After the BJP's elders anointed Shivraj Singh Chouhan the chief ministerial candidate way in advance, the moment of truth is now upon him. As he leads the party into the Assembly election, the certitudes of Madhya Pradesh's bipolar polity are under serious threat. For the first time ever, resurgent caste outfits like the BSP with its social engineering that hinges on upper castes, and rebels like Uma Bharati's Bharatiya Janshakti (BJ) threaten to play the spoiler, if not upset Chouhan's applecart.

Despite being the chief minister, he has always remained down-to-earth and amiable. Coupled with his artless but powerful delivery from the podium, it helped Chouhan acquire the



PANKAJ TIWARI